

looking to join international carriers, especially Middle-eastern ones. “Once airlines like Qatar Airways and Emirates start getting their new aircraft, the pilots from here would like to go there because the pay and work-life balance are much better there,” says a First Officer with IndiGo who has been flying for four and a half years.

A bigger concern is that the situation, as it stands today, is only to cater to the demand of planes on order. But India, the fastest growing aviation market and third largest market globally, is woefully underserved with 700 aircraft. China has 7,000 aircraft. “Planes are going full and ticket rates are touching the sky, which is a good sign for the industry and clearly means more capacity is required,” says Hemanth. “There are 200 million domestic and international passengers in India currently. In 2043, we may reach 1.3-1.6 billion passengers,” says CAPA’s Agarwal.

Union Minister for Civil Aviation Jyotiraditya Scindia said at the BT MindRush event in April that India has 94 per cent penetration of air travel left to achieve. “Out of the 1.38 billion people in our country, 144 million travel by air. Of those, many are repeat travellers. So, the penetration rate in India is hardly 3-4 per cent,” he had said. Airlines are also cognisant of the untapped opportunity. Akasa Air CEO Vinay Dube has said India’s youngest airline plans to place a “significant triple-digit order” in 2023.

A pilot shortage could have a multi-pronged impact on the entire ecosystem, with the foremost being overworked and fatigued pilots putting passenger lives at risk. Under DGCA’s Flight Duty Time Limitations (FDTL), pilots are allowed to log in a maximum 8 hours of flying a day, 35 hours a week, 125 hours a month and 1,000 hours a year. But pilots allege that the guidelines have been created



“I don’t foresee the industry producing more than 130 captains cumulatively [in five years]. The shortfall is over 1,100 captains. Where will they come from?”

C.S. Randhawa
SECRETARY, FEDERATION
OF INDIAN PILOTS



“A 5-10 per cent shortage is considered a manpower challenge in any industry. So, if there’s a 100 per cent shortage, it could mean you are dead and buried”

Hemanth D.P.
CEO, ASIA PACIFIC FLIGHT
TRAINING ACADEMY

without adequate focus on Indian conditions. “Airlines use the FDTL to its outer limit without any thought. It has a cascading effect of fatigued pilots,” says the ICPA member, adding that the process to report fatigue at some airlines is so intimidating that pilots would much rather drag themselves to fly. A recent survey of 542 pilots by Safety Matters Foundation showed that 66 per cent of them admitted to falling asleep without planning/consent of the other crew or experienced micro sleep.

DGCA did not respond to BT’s queries on the pilot shortage in the country.

Fewer pilots can also lead to a skewed demand-supply of planes in the air and in turn send airfares soaring. “Now that fare caps have been removed, we could see fare spikes in the medium term due to a capacity reduction,” says CAPA’s

Agarwal. Grounded planes also bleed revenue for airlines and airports. An airline could lose out on ₹100 crore of potential revenues a year by grounding one 186+-capacity jet for two to three main sector flights a day, estimates Hemanth, a former chief commercial officer at GMR Hyderabad International Airport. “Airports, ideally, do not want parked planes. If one plane occupies a parking slot during peak time for three hours, I lose that many more customers.”

Overall, experts say, pilot shortage is a lose-lose-lose situation for passengers, airlines and the country. Ramping up indigenous training infrastructure is the only long-term solution. Until then, it may be hard to sit back, relax and enjoy the rest of the flight. **BT**

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